

Why you should audit your processes before automating

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Faced with a painful task, the temptation is to automate what already exists, straight away. That is usually a mistake. A process nobody has ever questioned almost always contains pointless steps, duplicated approvals, or detours inherited from a constraint that no longer exists. Automating it as it stands does not make it better — it simply runs the same flaws, faster, and out of sight.

Automating a bad process is driving into the wall more quickly

A business process is rarely built in one piece. It forms step by step, often in reaction to a one-off problem — a mistake nobody wants to see again, an unhappy customer nobody wants to meet twice. Every addition had a reason at the moment it was decided. Years later the reason has sometimes gone but the step has stayed. Automating that process without looking at it first means carving those detours into a tool that will never question them.

What a process audit actually uncovers

- 1 Redundant steps.** The same information typed in two different places, one decision approved by two people, a check that duplicates a check already done upstream.
- 2 Invisible bottlenecks.** A task that looks harmless but which, in practice, only one person can do — and which puts everything else on hold the moment that person is unavailable.
- 3 Steps that have outlived their purpose.** A check introduced for a tool nobody uses any more, an approval demanded by a customer who left long ago, a box to tick that nobody can quite explain.
- 4 Breaks in the information chain.** One file that changes format or medium as it moves between teams (paper, spreadsheet, email, software), with a risk of loss or mis-copying at every handover.

The time hidden inside current processes

The time a process wastes almost never appears on a single budget line. It is diluted: a few minutes here re-typing information already known, a wait there for an approval to arrive, an email exchange to clear up a request that could have been clear from the start. Taken one at a time, each moment looks negligible. Added up over a year and across everyone involved, it often comes to several weeks of work.

The hidden money: what an unexamined process costs

Beyond the time, an un-audited process costs in three ways that are rarely recognised as related:

- 1 **The direct cost of the time spent** by the people carrying out steps that have become pointless or duplicated.
- 2 **The cost of the errors it produces** — information passed badly between two steps always ends up costing more to correct afterwards than it would have cost to prevent.
- 3 **The opportunity cost:** time locked into an inefficient process is time not spent on higher-value work — business development, customer relationships, improving the product or the service.

What a process audit looks like in practice

A process audit does not have to be long or complicated to be useful. In a smaller company it usually comes down to a few steps:

- 1 **Map the process as it is really carried out** — not as it is supposed to be on paper. The two versions almost always diverge, and the lost time usually hides in the gap.
- 2 **Time or estimate each step**, so you know where the time actually goes rather than trusting intuition.
- 3 **Identify the highly variable steps** — the ones that happen differently every time — because those are what need clarifying before any automation.
- 4 **Sort the steps** into those that are repetitive and predictable (good automation candidates), those that need human judgement (keep them), and those that are simply pointless (remove them).

The signals that it is time to audit

- 1 **Nobody on the team can explain why a step exists any more** — usually a sign that it no longer serves anything.
- 2 **The same kind of error keeps coming back** at the same point in the process, despite reminders and extra checks.
- 3 **A process depends on one person**, whose absence brings everything else to a halt.
- 4 **The company has changed tools or changed size** since the process was last thought through, without the process being revised to match.

Where to start?

A process audit does not have to be exhaustive to be useful — often one process, properly looked at, is enough to show where the time and the money are really going. That is what we do together in a first conversation.

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